

modesty norms or reduce the space for behaviour change (Bohnet, 2016.). So even when the situation gives a clear form of social permission, structural factors can still pose greater risks for women when they present themselves. Without considering these mechanisms, it is difficult for the experiment to fully explain how gender differences in visibility within organisations.

Based on these perspectives, the experiment by Tradenta et al. (2025) offers useful insights, but its external validity is limited by the setting, the type of audience, and the absence of organisational aspects. To address these gaps, it is necessary to test modesty norms in situations that more closely reflect actual workplace conditions. The next section develops a research design based on this idea.

5. Research Proposal

The study by Tradenta et al. (2025) shows that modesty norms can limit women's willingness to promote themselves in prosocial situations. But the experimental setting is still far from real workplaces, as the audience is anonymous, hierarchical structures are absent, and evaluations are not related to career outcomes. Since these elements matter a lot in work environments, this section proposes a new research design to study the main question of this paper: how modesty norms influence women's self-promotion in a workplace context.

5.1 Research Questions

Based on the earlier discussion, this study focuses on the following questions:

- Do women still show a lower level of self-promotion in a task that looks similar to real workplace situations?
- Does the type of audience (supervisor, colleague, anonymous evaluator) change women's level of self-promotion?
- If a social permission cue is given, will the gender gap become smaller?
- If self-promotion leads to real consequences, such as money or reputation rewards, will the gender gap change when incentives are different?

These questions extend earlier findings from prosocial settings to environments that have hierarchy and performance consequences.

5.2 Hypotheses

Based on theory and the literature, the following testable hypotheses can be proposed:

H1: Women promote themselves less than men in workplace situations.

H2: The gender gap is largest when the audience is a supervisor, because hierarchy increases the risk of negative social judgment.

H3: When a social permission cue is provided (for example, when employees are encouraged to describe their contributions), the gender gap becomes smaller.

H4: Under economic or reputation incentives, overall self-promotion increases compared to no-incentive conditions.

H5 (exploratory): Incentives may change the size of the gender gap. The direction is uncertain and needs empirical testing.

These hypotheses follow the logic of Tradenta et al. but extend it to settings that are closer to actual workplaces.

5.3 Experimental Design

The experiment contains three main parts. First, participants are recruited from working adults or students with some work experience. A sample of around 300 – 500 people should be enough for statistical power. Second, participants complete a simple workplace-related task. It can be a short analytical assignment or a simulated project contribution. After finishing the task, they write a self-presentation that explains their performance. This text is sent to one type of audience. The level of self-promotion is measured by how many achievements they mention, the amount of positive language, and their self-ratings.

The experiment employed a three-factor between-subjects design. The first factor is the audience. Participants write to either a supervisor, a colleague, or an anonymous evaluator. These groups differ in how much power they have and how formal the situation feels. The second factor is the social permission cue. Some participants receive a short message before writing, indicating that they are encouraged to provide more details about their performance and is considered professional in this situation. Others do not receive such a message. This setting

allows us to see whether a small signal can reduce worries about appearing too self-focused. The third factor is the incentive condition. In this version, participants are told that their payment partly depends on how an evaluator judges both their task performance and their self-presentation. High scores lead to extra money and a small reputation reward. In the no-incentive condition, everyone is paid the same.

After receiving the instructions, participants are randomly assigned to one combination of the three factors. They read the scenario, complete the task, and then write their self-presentation. Figure 2 in the text shows the full procedure. Besides the main outcome variables, the study also collects information on age, work experience, and self-efficacy. These variables help control for basic differences between participants. The analysis uses models that include interaction terms between gender and the three factors. This makes it possible to see how audience type, the social cue, and incentives influence gender differences in self-promotion under a more workplace-like environment.

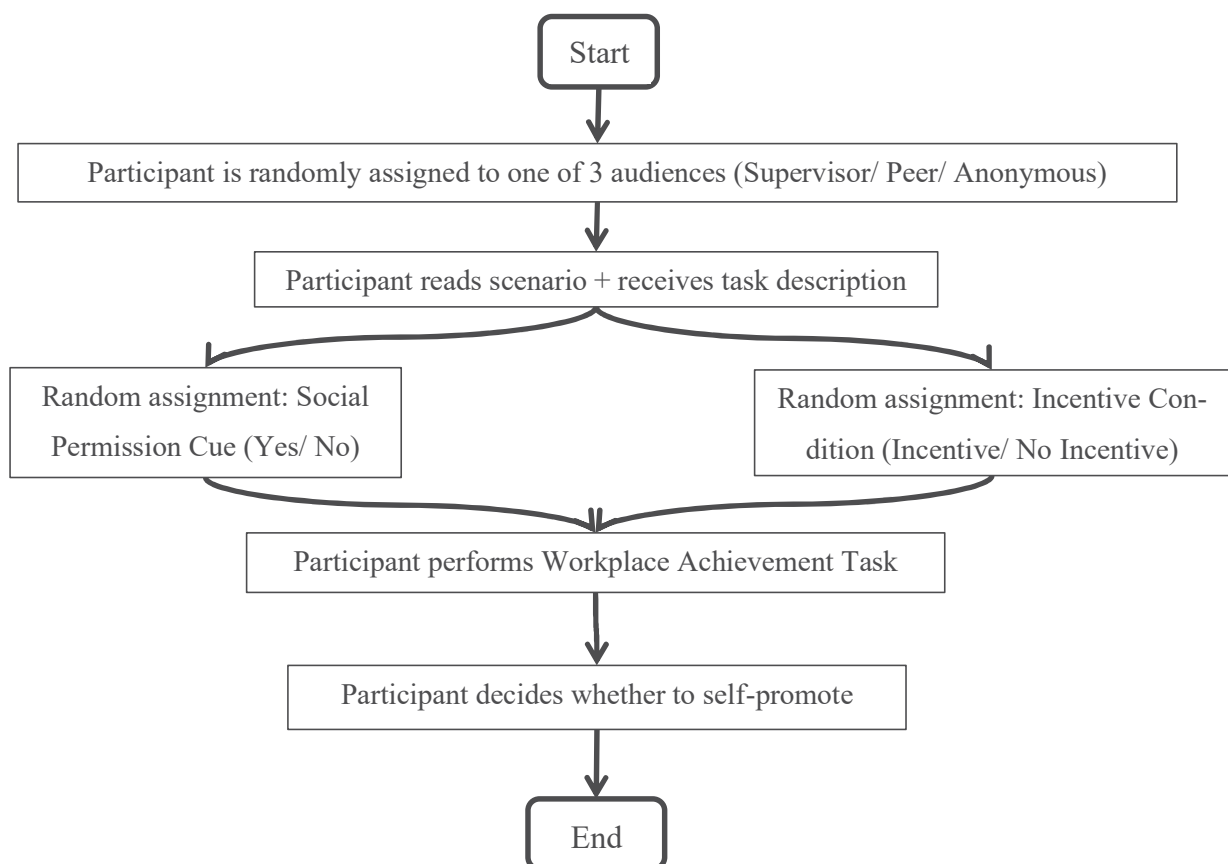


Abbildung 2: Overview of the Experimental Procedure. (Source: own illustration based on the proposed design.)

For the analysis, the three experimental factors-audience type, social permission cue, and incentive condition-are treated as separate between-subjects variables. The main goal is to see how these conditions shape self-promotion for men and women. To do this, the models include interaction terms between gender and each factor. This helps show whether the effect of a certain condition becomes stronger or weaker for one gender. The data can be analysed using OLS or ordered logit models, depending on how the outcome variable is distributed. These models allow a straightforward test of the hypotheses.

5.4 Expected Results

Based on the literature, the expected results are:

- Women promote themselves less than men in the no-cue condition
- The gender gap may be larger when the audience is a supervisor
- The social permission cue increases women's self-promotion and reduces the gender gap
- Incentives increase overall self-promotion because the presentation affects real rewards
- Incentives may change the direction of the gender gap:
- If women overcome modesty norms when rewards are clear, the gap becomes smaller
- If competitive incentives trigger stronger reactions among men, the gap may grow
- If these results appear, they will support the idea that modesty norms extend into workplace situations.

The research design offers a way to study how modesty norms influence behaviour in settings that resemble real organisations.